Genshin Impact - Sumeru Spec Script

Quest description: With Al-Haitham having narrowly managed to rescue Kaveh from that sand-sunken ruin, the roommates return to Sumeru City. Time to give Sachin's maddening research back to the Archon of Wisdom.

INT. SANCTUARY OF SURASTHANA - MORNING

Dendro Archon KUSANALI hovers a few meters off the ground, cross-legged and deep in meditation. Dendro energy swirls around her in green, glowing arcs. Behind, her assistant "HAT GUY" leans against the wall, scowling at the ground and fiddling with his Anemo Vision. Suddenly, his head snaps up to face the doors ahead of him. Kusanali's eyes flutter open, and she lands gracefully on her feet.

Akademiya Scribe ALHAITHAM strolls into the Sanctuary, with KAVEH (his estranged roommate? rival? friend?) stumbling along beside him. Kusanali offers a light wave, to which Alhaitham nods once in acknowledgment. Hat Guy swiftly pushes off from the wall.

KAVEH
(bowing awkwardly)
Lesser Lord Kusanali!

KUSANALI
Thank you for coming.

Hat Guy, surging forward with a burst of whooshing wind, stops directly before Kaveh, who yelps and staggers back.

HAT GUY
Where is it?

KAVEH
Huh? Where is—?

AL-HAITHAM
Right here.

He produces SACHIN's research, thick treatises on the greed of humanity and inevitability of violence; Kaveh flinches and averts his eyes, pained. Hat Guy snatches the volumes and saunters back to Kusanali. He smirks in satisfaction as he flips through them.

HAT GUY
You know, it's actually pretty funny, how a couple of books could drive humans to such desolate lengths. Are you all really that weak? Or can you just not comprehend the fact your lives have no meaning?

He hands off the volumes to Kusanali, then returns to his earlier place. Kusanali stares at the books.

KUSANALI
I personally derived no amusement from reading Sachin's work. Although to some extent, I can agree that it is interesting how his views have such unique impacts on certain people.
(to Kaveh)
I will now reseal the research, and this time I will not unseal them for any reason.

KAVEH
Good, yes, that's... good.
(muttering)
No one else shall read them and suffer.

ALHAITHAM
Hmph. It's a shame, really. Sachin's views were so novel, and his methodology so practical. If only someone else could be his successor...

Kusanali has begun sealing the books. Suspended in air, they bathe in ebbing green energy until they disappear.

KUSANALI
It is simply too dangerous.

ALHAITHAM
Well, yesterday's danger could have been easily avoided if Kaveh

hadn't read the research in the first place.

EXT. AVIDYA FOREST MONTAGE

Flashes of moments from the final round of the Interdarshan Championship. Kaveh crashing to the dirt as he caught the DIADEM OF KNOWLEDGE. Kaveh panting and clutching his aching head. The diadem sparkling, shadowy black wisps spooling out of it. Sachin's white ghostly form shimmering before the stage. Kaveh throwing down the diadem, letting it shatter into little shards.

ALHAITHAM (V.O.)
Was it morbid curiosity? Or perhaps, as an empathetic scholar, you figured it was unfair to dismiss his research without attempting to understand it first? Whatever the case, the cognitive dissonance of juxtaposing his nihilism with your optimism tore you apart. Again.

INT. SANCTUARY OF SURASTHANA - MORNING

ALHAITHAM
(arms crossed, looking at Kaveh)
All by your own doing.

KAVEH
Ugh, what would you know?! Besides, let's not pretend *your* actions yesterday were perfect, Mr. Tough Guy!

Kusanali frowns and tilts her head at the men. She discreetly uses her elemental skill to read their thoughts, which Hat Guy notices with a raised brow. We see flashes of Alhaitham's experiences from the previous day.

INT/EXT. DESERT MONTAGE

Alhaitham shielding his eyes from the harsh sun as he treks past Aaru Village. The pyramid ruins looming in the setting-sun distance. Hostile primal constructs spawning in, surrounding him.

KAVEH (V.O.)
You can't always be such a lone wolf!

ALHAITHAM (V.O.)
There's a difference between my self-reliance and yours. When I refuse help, it's because I don't need the extra hassle of dealing with others. When *you* refuse help, it's despite the fact you're in desperate need of it.

Alhaitham kneeling in the sand, coated in dust and blood, near death. Then, a helping hand reaching out. Three figures entering with him into the ruin where Kaveh had gone mad. Cyno, Dehya, Candace. Kaveh's friends.

ALHAITHAM (V.O.)
As for what happened yesterday, I only ended up accepting help because I hadn't intended to fend off so many monsters to save you.

KAVEH (V.O.)
Oh, so you were just planning on *leaving me* to succumb to that fate?

ALHAITHAM (V.O.)
Do you think I *wanted* any of this to happen? You have to realize there's only so much I could have done when you were so *eager* to die.

INT. SANCTUARY OF SURASTHANA - MORNING

Kaveh's eyes widen, their surfaces glossy like he's about to cry. In the reflection shines the image of Kaveh's father, another victim of Sachin's despair and nihilism.

KAVEH
You...! Why can't you ever talk to other people like a normal human being?!

ALHAITHAM
(shrugging)
I've gotten plenty far in life without knowing how. Clearly, proper social interaction isn't requisite for success.

KAVEH
(wagging a finger at him)
One day, you'll see! One day you'll look around and realize that your wealth and comfort mean *nothing* because you will die alone, because you refuse to form relationships with other people!

ALHAITHAM
I'll die alone? That's awfully ironic coming from you.

Kaveh clenches his fists, furious. He's barely recovered from his injuries and he already wants to get in a fight.

KAVEH
Ugh, this is why I can't stand you! You're just too stubborn to see past your own rigid opinions!

ALHAITHAM
(side-eyeing him)
You know, I was just about to say the same thing to you.

KUSANALI
Alright, that's enough.

Crossing her arms, Kusanali shakes her head in disappointment. Kaveh sheepishly rubs the back of his neck. How could he act so foolish in front of Sumeru's Archon?

KUSANALI
Oh, you two... What is to be done? I think you could keep arguing for decades before realizing the obvious truth before you.

ALHAITHAM
What obvious truth?

KUSANALI
(bringing her hand to her chin)
Hm... Do you have any spare Mora? Just one coin will do.

Kaveh frantically pats down his pockets before groaning and shaking his head. Alhaitham removes a golden coin from the pouch on his belt and tosses it to her. It flies through the air in a graceful arc, flipping in circles, until it's caught in her outstretched palm. She holds it up to the light, turns and adjusts it, observing.

KUSANALI
I'll try to keep this brief to avoid sounding preachy. I want you to imagine your so-called ideals—that is, your temperament, your personal philosophies, your perspective on this world—could be condensed into a small circle: one side of this coin. Taking the coin as a whole, it has two sides which diametrically oppose each other. But though these opposite sides cannot ever be on the same side, that does not mean they are in disunion. Why, in fact, there can be no coin without both sides joined together. And for a fair coin, the sides balance out.

She nods, satisfied with her explanation, and tosses the coin back to Alhaitham. After catching it, he looks to Kaveh, and then Hat Guy. They share an equally bewildered expression.

ALHAITHAM / KAVEH / HAT GUY
What?

KUSANALI
You two mirror each other. Kaveh's empathy with Alhaitham's

self-regard. Both of you have ideals you are attached to, and neither one is inherently more correct than the other. However, although your personalities and views may contradict each other, that does not mean you can never reconcile with one another.

ALHAITHAM / KAVEH / HAT GUY
Ohhhh.

HAT GUY
Tch, why didn't you just say it that way the first time?

KUSANALI
(giggling)
I suppose my metaphors need more work, then.

ALHAITHAM
I can recognize the validity of that sentiment while also maintaining the belief that Kaveh's ideals—or his 'side of the coin', in the case of your metaphor—are inherently flawed. What do you say to that?

KUSANALI
I am not trying to debate you. I only wish to impart some...wisdom, per se, freely given. There is nothing wrong with sticking to a personal philosophy, but if you two really want to repair your relationship, you have to learn to make compromises for each other.

KAVEH
What makes you think I *want* any sort of relationship with him?!

KUSANALI
As long as you lie to yourselves, you will never be happy.

ALHAITHAM
I was plenty happy before Kaveh moved in.

KUSANALI
(with a patient smile)
Alhaitham, do you still remember what you wrote in Sachin's notes?

KAVEH
Oh, yeah, I remember it! In the ancient script, what was it?— 'Lofty ideals cannot defend against nihilism, but little decisions can.' Yeah, what was that about?!

ALHAITHAM
'Lofty ideals may provide no defense at all against nihilism, but perhaps little decisions can. By their own choice, the idealist seeks to bring happiness to all, while denying themselves the same. Thus they shall never reach even the borders of truth until they wipe away the ignorance that blinds them.'

KUSANALI
That's the one. I know you wrote it with Kaveh, Sachin, and similar idealists in mind, but I implore you, Alhaitham, to think again. In a way, it applies to yourself too.

INT/EXT. MONTAGE

As she speaks, Kaveh glances sadly at Alhaitham, then looks away. Alhaitham does the same. They don't make eye contact.

KUSANALI (V.O.)
If you two are opposite sides of a fair coin, or mirror reflections of each other, then how can Kaveh's views be inherently flawed

and yours not? How can only he be blinded by ignorance? I know that when you debate with and criticize Kaveh, you have good intentions, but intentions aren't enough.

Flashes of times spent together. Drinking in the tavern, playing cards with Cyno and Tighnari, writing their joint thesis. A shot of the green-roofed house they share.

KUSANALI (V.O.)
The highest form of knowledge is truth. Thus the lowest ignorance is falsehood. Neither of you can achieve true wisdom until you achieve truth itself—that is, honesty within yourselves and with each other. As long as you hide from your own emotions and from each other—neither of you can ever reach the 'borders of truth.'

INT. SANCTUARY OF SURASTHANA - MORNING

They've both gone silent. Behind Kusanali, Hat Guy seems impressed. Kusanali laughs and scratches her head.

KUSANALI
That's all from me. Apologies if I did get a little too preachy there. I only wish... Well, you both are some of the brightest minds of this generation of Sumeru's scholars—it would truly be a shame to lose either of you so soon.
(to Kaveh)
Oh, and do remember: The Akademiya always has a place for you.
(waving)
Farewell.

Alhaitham and Kaveh face each other, in apprehension or understanding, finally meeting one another's eyes. Equals.

END QUEST